

Russia: Voters back stability over escalation

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【メール原文】

United Russia's expanded constitutional majority will strengthen the Kremlin's hand, while the failure of hawkish pro-war parties suggests the Russian

Quick take

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Voters wary of escalation as Putin expands constitutional majority

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

What Happened

The Kremlin's United Russia party won 57.83% of the party-list vote in the 19-21 September Duma election, up from 49.8% in 2021; turnout was 59.32%—the highest since 2011. Combined with single-mandate districts, where United Russia candidates led in 208 of 225 seats, the party is set to hold more than 350 of 450 seats, expanding its constitutional majority. A Just Russia and Rodina, the most hawkish pro-war parties, both fell short of the 5% threshold.

Our Take

The result will give the Kremlin an even freer hand than before. A constitutional majority means United Russia can amend the constitution or pass any law without negotiating with other factions. With a larger majority for the ruling party, the next Duma will be more of a rubber stamp than the outgoing one, at the exact moment it will be asked to approve successive wartime budgets.

Regional bureaucracies passed the test of delivering a clean, controlled result. United Russia's victory was never in doubt, but there were questions about execution amid signs of a straining system. Turnout was artificially front-loaded: 29% of the total vote was cast on day one alone, nearly double the 2021 share, driven by remote electronic voting that employers can monitor and effectively coerce. The heaviest first-day turnout clustered in regions where employers and authorities appear to have pushed staff to vote early. There were disruptions on Sunday, particularly long lines for paper-ballot voting in Moscow, which plausibly deterred less compliant voters.

The failure of more hardline parties shows the public is cautious of escalation. A Just Russia and Rodina, which ran the most bellicose, escalatory campaigns with respect to Ukraine, both missed the threshold to enter the next parliament. The more moderate New People party gained ground and placed second in electronic voting outside Moscow. Meanwhile, Yabloko, the only openly anti-war party, was barred from federal lists entirely and won no districts.

The Russian population will likely remain compliant and resigned. Despite high anxiety caused by Ukrainian strikes, gasoline shortages, and economic deterioration, the election went smoothly for Putin. Russians' concerns have not translated into appetite for extreme hawkishness or territorial ambition either. The results indicate that the electorate's dominant demands are safety and stability rather than escalation or change. That leaves the Kremlin with a manufactured supermajority and a compliant chamber, but little evidence of public enthusiasm for continued escalation.

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